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Dialogue With Anthony M. Platt

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Dialogue With Anthony M. Platt*

An Interview Conducted and Prepared for *Issues in Criminology*

By Elliott Currie**

December 1972

Currie: "Tell me something about your education and how it has influenced your thinking."

Platt: "I had most of my education in England. I started at Manchester Grammar School, a highly specialized high school—often called a scholarship factory—where I was trained to take exams and prepare for the university. Michael Young's famous book, *The Rise of the Meritocracy*, was partly based on his experiences as a teacher there and his antipathy to educational elitism and channeling. After I left Manchester Grammar School, I spent three years at Oxford University studying jurisprudence as an undergraduate. I had some vague notions about becoming a lawyer but I was mainly studying law because I didn't have a clear idea of what else I wanted to do. That was typical in England of people studying law. After three years under David Yardley, a conservative constitutional lawyer who at that time campaigned in support of capital punishment, I decided against a legal career."

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Currie: "What brought you here to the School of Criminology?"

Platt: "After I finished my degree at Oxford, about ten years ago, I wanted to travel and get away from England for a while. In my last semester at Oxford, I met Ted Sarbin at a seminar organized by Nigel Walker, the English criminologist who was then at Nuffield College and who just recently took over from Radzinowicz as Director of the Institute of Criminology in Cambridge. Sarbin, who is now at the University of California's Santa Cruz campus, was visiting from Berkeley and gave a lecture on role theory and crime. He suggested that I try to do graduate studies at either Harvard or Berkeley. I had not heard much about Berkeley then (it was before the Free Speech Movement), but Lenny Bruce and Jack Kerouac were heroes of mine and I had always wanted to visit the West Coast. So I decided against Harvard and chose Berkeley. It was a totally irrational decision, and under other circumstances I might have gone to the East Coast and spent my life constructing useless prediction tables."

Currie: "What did you find when you got to Berkeley? What kinds of things did you get into? What differences did you find from the English system?"

Platt: "I found the educational system very different. It was a lot more infantile in the sense that it expected students to be far more passive and take a consumer attitude to knowledge. I'm not trying to glorify the English system, but universities there generally allow students more responsibility and self-direction—especially at the undergraduate level. Coming from the tutorial system where I met with an instructor every week and discussed the progress of my studies, I was somewhat mindblown by Berkeley's IBM education, quizzes and mid-terms, book reports, true and false tests, etc. Before the Free Speech Movement I was very disenchanted with Berkeley and was planning to return to England at the end of the year. About that time I met Bernard Diamond, a psychoanalyst and legal scholar, who got me interested in the field of law and psychiatry and hired me as his research assistant. I got really interested in his work, took the job and decided to stay on longer."

Currie: "How did you get involved in the research which led to your dissertation on *The Child Savers*?"

Platt: "I did research with Diamond on the history and significance of legal definitions of mental illness. In the course of that research, it became clear that there were many parallels between legal concep-

tions of madness and legal conceptions of immaturity. In one article we suggested that the law characterized the criminally insane as unsocialized, undeveloped and therefore infantile. This was responsible for my interest in the legal definitions of 'juvenile' crime and the jurisdiction of the juvenile court. This development happened to coincide with the general interests of David Matza who had just completed *Delinquency and Drift* and was willing to sponsor my dissertation on the origins and ideology of the juvenile court. With Matza's support I became a research assistant at the Center for the Study of Law and Society where I wrote *The Child Savers*."

Currie: "What other kinds of intellectual influences were acting on you at that time? *The Child Savers* comes out of an interactionist perspective. Who else besides Matza influenced you?"

Platt: "I was very strongly influenced by the labeling theorists who at that time were the "young Turks" of criminology and seemed to offer a radical alternative to traditional positivism and delinquency control theorists of the early 60's. Several labeling theorists were either in or visited the Center—people like Aaron Cicourel, Howie Becker, Jerry Skolnick, Shelly Messinger, David Sudnow and Ed Lemert. Becker's *Outsiders* was in vogue, Lemert's misleadingly titled *Social Pathology* was being widely circulated, and Jerry Skolnick's *Justice Without Trial* suggested a new direction for studying how 'crime' is created and regulated. The labeling perspective, especially its apparently critical posture on the institutions of criminal 'justice,' was very appealing and I embraced it too quickly and without a proper examination of its ideological assumptions."

Currie: "Your recent work reflects a departure from labeling theory and more of a Marxist influence. What caused you to move away from the interactionist perspective?"

Platt: "There were several reasons. One reason was that my developing involvement in political practice made it clear that I lacked a comprehensive political theory of society, and labeling theory addressed only a small part of my concern. Another reason was my eventual dissatisfaction with the uses to which labeling theory was being put—it was coopted by government and agency researchers and integrated, as in Johnson's Crime Commission, into a social control perspective. And finally I found that the analytical categories of labeling theory were totally inadequate for understanding the major crimes of American society: imperialism, racism, sexism, unequal wealth, etc. Contemporary labeling theory is generally relativistic and

amoral, and, as Gouldner has noted, has a tendency to indulge romanticism and irresponsible hipsterism. Its social-psychological framework constrains the scope of theory by focusing on interactions and transactions between individuals or groups. These kinds of studies are useful so long as they are connected with a structural analysis of the political economy. But labeling theorists do not usually make these connections. Instead they focus on middle-management institutions (prisons, police, probation, etc.) and generally ignore how and why these institutions exist. I agree with the observation of the English sociologists Ian Taylor and Laurie Taylor that the labeling theorists see society as made up of individuals playing a giant slot machine. The machine is fixed and only some players get paid off. The losers get frustrated and either kick the machine or leave. Nobody is interested in who put the machine there and who gets its profits. Criticism of the game is confined to tampering with the machine so that players win more consistently and losers don't get too unhappy. I suppose I got tired of tinkering with the machine."

Currie: "I want to return to what you were saying earlier. There was an interim between the writing and publication of *The Child Savers* when you went to the University of Chicago. Can you talk about what you did there?"

Platt: "After I left Berkeley I turned down an offer to teach in England and instead accepted a research fellowship at the University of Chicago's Center for Studies in Criminal Justice. I was interested in going because I had done a great deal of research for *The Child Savers* there and Chicago of course had great historical significance for criminology and sociology. Norval Morris and Hans Mattick directed the Center at that time and Harry Kalven, Hans Zeisel, and Jerry Skolnick were there. I was mainly interested in studying with Frank Allen whose book *The Borderland of Criminal Justice* left its mark on my work. But as soon as I arrived, Allen became Dean of the Law School in Ann Arbor. That left me at the Center as the only 'authority' on the juvenile court at a time when the Ford Foundation, the Crime Commission, the Supreme Court, government agencies and research factories were interested in reforming the juvenile court as part of the 'war against crime.' Aside from a little teaching and contact with important influences like Dick Flacks, one of the founders of SDS, and Marlene Dixon, I spent nearly all my time doing research on the Cook County juvenile court. Within several weeks I found myself with the honorific title of Research Director studying a project called Legal Services to Youth which had been

funded by the Ford Foundation to the tune of about \$100,000. The project was a prototype of literally hundreds of 'pilot' programs and 'demonstration' projects around the country. Given its assumptions, it was one of the best and most sophisticated of its kind. The aim of the project was to provide legal services for young Blacks in one of Chicago's southside ghettos, and to study and evaluate the program so that it could be duplicated in other places if it was successful. My task as the researcher was to evaluate the administration and consequences of the project. It was essentially a technocratic orientation. The Supreme Court's decision in the *Gault* case and the recommendation of the Crime Commission meant that lawyers were going to be a regular part of the juvenile court system. I was supposed to come up with proposals for implementing this policy in a smooth and efficient manner—the typical technocratic task.”

Currie: “As a result of this project you began to develop a critical perspective on liberal reforms in the justice system. Could you talk more about this?”

Platt: “It was a critical turning point for me, especially in terms of how I regarded myself as an ‘intellectual’ and academic careerist. It took me about a year and a half to come to terms with and understand my alienation from the project. The program was typically liberal and reformist. While in the short-run it appeared humanitarian and benevolent, in the long run it did great injustices to the Black community. It didn’t create a strong community organization, it channeled residents away from political action, and it encouraged the community to rely on professionals and experts who did not have any kind of stake in long-range development of their constituency. More significantly, the project served important public relations functions for the University of Chicago. Here was the image of a benevolent University concerned about the misery of its ghetto neighbors. The reality of course is a University which through ‘urban renewal’ and other strategies of expansion has helped to maintain the ghetto and encourage divisiveness in the Black community. The project came to an end when the Director of the Center asked me if I had collected sufficient data to write up the project. There was no real concern for discovering ways of continuing the project or finding other sources of funding. The project existed for the research and not for the people it was supposed to serve. While the staff of the legal office itself were all Blacks, the project was directed and administered by ‘professional’ whites in the University. All the critical decisions about hiring, firing, budgets, resources, etc. were made in the

University. It was a perfect example of liberal colonialism, of missionary-style politics based on guilt and paternalism. I left the project and the University of Chicago very disillusioned with that kind of short-range remedialism and, more importantly, very upset at my own participation in such a fraud. I should have known better and I still really regret my contribution to that project."

Currie: "After that you came back to Berkeley to teach in the School of Criminology and work on a report for the Violence Commission. Maybe you could talk a little about your participation in the Violence Commission."

Platt: "The Violence Commission was established by President Johnson after the deaths of Kennedy and King. It was a massive project, involving more people and resources than even the Kerner Commission. I worked for Jerry Skolnick who directed the Task Force on Collective Protest, and after six months of frantic work we completed *The Politics of Protest*. I worked mainly on the chapters concerning Black protest and the legal system. Even now I'm fairly happy with my work on that book and I learned a great deal from working with you on the chapter about the history of the Black movement. But I think the book as a whole has many deficiencies due to its liberal assumptions and conflict theory orientation. While it gives a sympathetic critique of various contemporary protest movements—Blacks, students, anti-war, etc.—it ultimately cops out by failing to explain oppression in terms of the larger forces of imperialism and capitalism. It assumes that the government does not properly understand these protest movements and that they would act more reasonably and justly if they did. It's probably the case, however, that the government has a very good understanding of what's going on and that is exactly why they use every means, from bullets to ideological techniques of persuasion, to repress these movements. The book was sanitized of ideological discussion on the grounds that policy-makers might be offended. The main problem with the book, as I see it now, is that it was written for progressive forces *within* government and academia and not for the movements it was studying. In this sense, it was reminiscent of my experiences in Chicago with the legal aid project. I don't think I will work for a commission again. Too many compromises have to be made."

Currie: "Is that because you think *The Politics of Protest* had a negative impact or because it compromised your political principles?"

Platt: “I think intellectual work is very important, but should take its priorities and direction from ongoing political struggles. Our scholarship should, to use Marx’s phrase, consist of ‘practical critical activity.’ *The Politics of Protest* was not the work of persons engaged in ongoing political struggles. We did not consult and actively involve the ‘protesters’ in order to see what importance our work might have, how it might advance the struggle of oppressed people, and so on. The book was, despite its pretensions, an elitist study, geared to an audience of academics and liberal politicians. It did, however, make some contribution to understanding the historical development of particular struggles and to a critique of conventional collective behavior theory. Even though it challenged their work on their own terms, it did an effective job of exposing the social control assumptions of theorists like Neil Smelser and Morris Janowitz.”

Currie: “Let’s look a little more closely at the shifts in your thinking that have taken place even since you worked on *The Politics of Protest*. Maybe one way of understanding this is to discuss your own critique of *The Child Savers* and your other recent work.”

Platt: “My work in the last two or three years has been organized around trying to develop a critique of liberal criminological theory and in the process to re-educate myself. The system of higher education in this country prepares intellectuals for privileged roles of incredible arrogance and a sense of inflated self-importance. We should reward teachers who continue to regard themselves as students and learners after they have completed their formal education. The last couple of years has been a time of confronting some harsh realities about my earlier work and inadequate education. This partly explains why I edited a book on *The Politics of Riot Commissions*. While I was interested in the liberal ideology underlying commission reports and the ways in which such efforts serve to coopt or undermine political movements, I was also examining my own participation and responsibilities in the Violence Commission. I am presently working on another book now with Renetia Martin concerning the 1935 Harlem riot and its political consequences. The study focuses on how an original evaluation of the riot by E. Franklin Frazier was first censored by a predominantly liberal commission and then shelved by Mayor LaGuardia. It’s a complex book involving an analysis of the relationship between ideology, political movements and ruling class hegemony. Because it deals with sensitive issues—Frazier’s socialism, Black and white struggles, government suppression, etc.—I’m trying to

work on the materials slowly and carefully. The shift in my thinking these days can best be seen in a paper I just completed for Blumberg's *Introduction to Criminology* which will be released later this year. It's an attempt to integrate my research on the child-savers with a class analysis and Marxist framework.

"The problem with *The Child Savers* is that it's too much of a muckraking work and focuses too much attention on the middle-class reformers who developed the technical machinery of the juvenile court and related institutions. The book stops short at the really interesting questions: Why did the child-saving reform movement develop at that particular time in the United States? How was this reform movement related to other reforms in the emerging welfare state? Where did the movement get its ideological and financial support? These kinds of questions were not really addressed in *The Child Savers*, and in this new paper I begin to rectify some of these deficiencies. The paper suggests that the child-saving movement was part of a much larger enterprise designed to rescue capitalism from what appeared like its imminent decline, to develop social integration without the constant use of coercion, and to accelerate the development of monopoly capitalism but under more stable and regulated conditions. While the United States launched its policies of imperialism abroad with the Spanish-American war at the end of the nineteenth century, at home it designed programs of social imperialism of which the juvenile court was only one part. It's interesting that my new analysis has come under criticism and scrutiny for being too ideological and politicized by persons who received *The Child Savers* with uncritical praise."

Currie: "You've been talking about shifts towards a concern for the relationship between criminal justice agencies like the juvenile court and the larger structure of monopoly capitalism, and the attempts on the part of corporate liberals to stabilize monopoly capitalism as a system. What kinds of things were you doing and reading that influenced you in this direction?"

Platt: "My re-education process comes primarily from the impact of political struggles over a ten year period. I came to the United States at the beginning of a period of intense political conflict, beginning with the Free Speech Movement and the creation of a vigorous anti-war movement. I was in Berkeley during FSM, the Third World students strike, the Eldridge Cleaver dispute, the Cambodia and Haiphong street demonstrations, People's Park, and the community control of police campaign. During my two years in Chicago, I saw

the massive rebellion following the murder of Martin Luther King and the police 'riot' at the Democratic National Convention in 1968. In Chicago I worked with Black political groups at a time when it was becoming less and less possible for whites to work in Black political organizations. I think my status as a 'foreigner' helped me a little in that respect. My experience in Chicago was a critical turning point, my first awareness of the magnitude and crimes of racism. I remember sitting in the courts after the King riot watching 3,000 Blacks get processed in squads of twenty while police and national guardsmen stood around the courtroom carrying sub-machine guns. That was a very heavy experience for me. It made it clear that there was no room for fence-sitting. Either you were on the side of the prisoners or of the guards.

"When I returned to Berkeley, I became much more active politically, doing anti-war work, campaigning for community control of the police and eventually joining a political collective. These experiences in the community had a profound impact on my self-image as an 'intellectual' and made it clear that I somehow had to integrate my intellectual and political roles. I basically agree with Marlene Dixon that it is the obligation of intellectuals to both develop theories of oppression and exploitation *and* to participate in the process of transforming society. I still think intellectual work is very important and in the last year or so I have been trying to learn as much as I can from persons, resources, and experiences outside the university. For a while I felt very ignorant and confused because I realized that I had not been educated to answer or investigate the really critical issues of our day. I still feel that way to a certain extent, but now I have more of a sense of what is to be done. I've been reading a lot—from the classics on Marxist-Leninist thought, to materials on the history of racism in the United States, to works by neo-Marxist historians like Kolko and Weinstein. Herman Schwendinger, a Marxist criminologist at Berkeley, has had a profound impact on my intellectual development and, in a more general sense, I have learned a great deal about teaching, working with students, and combining theory and practice from another colleague, Paul Takagi. I don't read the Criminology journals very much anymore. *Monthly Review*, *Socialist Revolution*, *New Left Review* and so on have much more to say about the important crimes—imperialism, racism, sexism, exploitation, etc. It's ironic that the 'criminals' have written better books on crime than the criminologists; take, for example, the work of Malcolm X, Eldridge Cleaver, Angela Davis, Brendan Behan, Sam Melville, George Jackson."

Currie: "Given all these influences and experiences, you began to think of yourself as a kind of radical criminologist. What does it mean to be a radical criminologist? How does that affect your work now? What should radical criminologists be teaching and doing?"

Platt: "That's a pretty broad question. I don't think anybody is really clear what the 'new criminology' should look like, but some guidelines are emerging. Let me preface my comments by saying that my ideas in this interview should not be regarded as purely personal statements, but rather as a reflection of a larger movement that is developing. The new criminology is not the work of a few idiosyncratic misfits. It is part of the changing consciousness of students and instructors which comes out of our practical experiences inside and outside the university. The new criminology has plenty to do.

"First, we need to develop a deep understanding of what criminology has been in the past. We are just beginning to realize that criminology has serviced domestic repression in the same way that economics, political science, and anthropology have greased the wheels and even manufactured some of the important parts of modern imperialism. The history of criminology is a perfect example of what Herbert Blumer calls agency-determined research. The modern criminal justice system—juvenile court, probation, parole, indeterminate sentencing, the rehabilitative ideal, half-way houses, etc.—was built with the active involvement of criminology. Given the ways in which this system has been used to repress and maintain the powerlessness of poor people, workers, people of color, and young people, it is not too far-fetched to characterize many criminologists as domestic war criminals. That analogy may be too crude and 'ideological' for most academics, but from the perspective of the victims of the legal system it is accurate. Read George Jackson's *Soledad Brother*, for example. Compared with other liberal social sciences, criminology has neither had a consistently powerful political influence nor the money to put its ideology to full practice. But in the last few years, especially under the Nixon administration, the federal government has made millions of dollars available to criminologists and 'police scientists.' This money is largely going to academics and consultants who are prepared to find new ways of training criminal justice personnel, new ways of controlling 'criminals,' new ways of preventing 'riots,' and new ways of diverting political opposition. In other words, the money is going to those who are willing to study and practice counter-insurgency. The new criminology must understand and reject the role we have played historically as architects of repression.

“Secondly, we need to re-define the concerns and interests of criminology. In the past we have been constrained by a legal definition of crime which restricts us to studying and ultimately helping to control only legally defined ‘criminals’ and, more to the point, this usually means persons who are processed through the courts and prisons. We need a new and more humanistic definition of crime, one which reflects the reality of a legal system based on power and privilege. To accept the legal definition of crime is to accept the fiction of neutral law. Herman Schwendinger and Julia Schwendinger have proposed in a recent article* that crime should be defined as a violation of basic human rights: the rights to decent food and shelter, to human dignity, to self-determination, etc. This may be a new concept for criminologists, but it’s a daily reality for oppressed people who know that the legal system commits much greater crimes against the people than the people commit against the system. A human rights definition of crime frees us to examine imperialism, racism, capitalism, sexism, exploitation and other political economic systems which contribute to human misery and deprive people of their potentialities. The State itself would also become a central focus of investigation as a criminogenic institution, from its complicity in corruption and duplicity (IT&T, the Watergate affair, police pay-offs, etc.) to the massive crime of genocide in Indochina.

“This new definition of crime not only leads to different kinds of theoretical work but also to new solutions. Under the legal definition, the solutions focus primarily on controlling the people who routinely go through the criminal justice system. Under the human rights definition, the solution to ‘crime’ lies in revolutionary transformation of society and elimination of the structural causes of human misery in the world. Of course there’s going to be a great deal of resistance to developing a radical criminology from university administrations, established criminological centers, and the handful of powerful research entrepreneurs who dominate the field.”

Currie: “I think that one of the objections to redefining crime in the larger sense is that it will make criminology into an imperialistic science. People will say, ‘Well, we know that racism is bad, imperialism is bad, sexism is bad, but they’re not really crimes. Aren’t we overstepping our bounds and spreading ourselves too thin?’ ”

Platt: “I’m not suggesting that we totally abandon the legal definition of crime or that we should abandon our work on the police,

*The Schwendingers, Herman and Julia, “Defenders of Order or Guardians of Human Rights?” *Issues in Criminology*, 5(2), Summer 1970.

courts, prisons, etc. But we certainly have to go beyond our conventional boundaries in order to make sense out of what we're doing. Intellectual inquiry shouldn't be carved into artificial domains like pieces of private property. Antonio Gramsci, the Italian Communist leader, said somewhere in his *Prison Notebooks* that all the essential questions of sociology are nothing other than questions of political science, *i.e.*, who controls and benefits from the society, how is power and wealth distributed, how can society be made more just, etc.? Similarly, in criminology we are addressing major questions about how a society defines and controls its 'criminals.' This isn't to suggest that criminologists should only study imperialism, racism and the like. Rather I'm suggesting that people who are studying crime should also have a comprehensive understanding of the larger political economy, otherwise they are likely to neglect crucial connections and become very cynical in their frustrated efforts to control 'crime.' In our work and studies we should follow the leadership of 'criminals' like George Jackson and Angela Davis who have made a lasting contribution to criminology."

Currie: "What kinds of radical research do you think should be done within the conventional subject matter of criminology?"

Platt: "There are many things to be done. We need careful and thorough historical research. We know very little about the historical development of the courts, police, and prisons in the United States. We know even less about the people who work for these agencies, where they come from, and how their constituency has changed over the last hundred years. On another subject, we need policy studies on contemporary crime control programs. What is the Nixon administration planning, what reforms are presently taking place, what policies are likely to emerge in the near future, etc.? These kinds of questions are very important and criminologists should spend more time trying to analyze government policies and less time helping to implement them."

Currie: "This raises an interesting question. Your last comment has been made for a long time by persons who don't think of themselves as radicals and who identify themselves with the interactionist wing of liberal criminology. What makes your view different?"

Platt: "There are some areas where liberal and radical scholarship overlap. The difference in this issue, I think, lies in commitment to a certain kind of political practice. Interactionist theorists do one of two things. They study powerful institutions either for aesthetic

reasons or with an eye toward liberal policy reforms. The radical theorist, on the other hand, organizes his or her intellectual work on the basis of practical priorities determined by oppressed groups. Historical scholarship or policy studies should not be a matter of aesthetic preference. Rather they should be used to understand past errors, to analyze the dynamics of exploitation, and to help build a revolutionary movement."

Currie: "Of course the obvious rejoinder by liberal criminologists would be that you are opening yourself up to the possibility of very biased 'ideological' research. What do you say to that?"

Platt: "I thought that debate was over by now because even liberal theorists admit that values and biases influence their work. 'Ideologue' is the new insult to discredit only left-wing scholars. When the values are conservative or liberal, then the work is glorified as 'objective' and 'responsible.' We need to make clearer distinctions between ideological research and sloppy research. Ideology is healthy and should be made explicit. At the same time we should do extraordinarily thorough research. It should be well constructed, scientific, and always aware of the pitfalls of sentimentality and romanticism. In fact, our research should be more thorough and careful than research done by liberal theorists because we have more to gain or lose by the consequences of our work."

Currie: "What does your perspective imply for teaching criminology? Do you think that radical criminologists should try to stay in the universities?"

Platt: "I think that we should continue to teach in universities as long as we are not required to compromise fundamental principles or until we're fired. There's a great deal of teaching to do in order to counteract the myths and lies about crime which pervade not only the mass media but also the criminology textbooks. Critical thinking about American society is absolutely necessary now if we are to properly understand and transform our political economy. The high percentage of the future personnel of the criminal justice agencies is going to college now. Whether or not we respect universities as educational institutions is almost besides the point. More and more people are going to college and to abandon them would be irresponsible and dangerous. We should try to remain in the universities and avoid the dangers of becoming too abstractly theoretical or too overcommitted to practice. Theory without practice leads to idealism, while practice without theory leads to ineffectiveness and ultimately to cynicism.

Through a combination of theory and practice we must work with students so that they learn through their own participation in struggles that the problems of crime cannot be addressed in isolation from other problems of exploitation and oppression. There is also the question of careers. Students are trying to decide where and how they want to work after leaving college. Many have made the decision not to work for repressive bureaucracies of social control (the police and prisons, for example) and others are not looking forward to getting burned out with the frustrations of a job in probation and parole. This is a very difficult problem and we must work with students to help them deal with these contradictions.”

Currie: “This discussion raises questions about the constituency of a radical criminology. Who is your audience and constituency?”

Platt: “There are different kinds of potential constituencies. I think that we need to develop an organization comparable to how the Medical Committee on Human Rights relates to the medical profession and the Lawyers Guild to the legal profession. There are basically three constituencies for criminology. First, there are the people working in the criminal justice agencies, especially parole and probation officers. This group for the most part has a humanistic training and many grievances about their working conditions. A second constituency are criminology and police science students. This group has increased enormously in the last few years due to government and foundation funding. We need to develop ways of reaching them and offering an alternative to government propaganda and technocratic journals like the *Journal of Criminology*, *Criminal Law and Police Science*. The third constituency are the people who make up the ‘clients’ and victims of the criminal justice system. We can serve these communities by providing technical assistance, resources, and other kinds of skills which universities have to offer. This doesn’t mean that we should be paternalistic, but rather that we should offer our skills in service to the people and demonstrate through our own commitment to struggling against injustice that we are struggling in *our* own best interest as well.”

Currie: “Your perspective raises the issue of personal and professional survival. Do you want to talk about your own tenure difficulties at Berkeley?”

Platt: “It’s true that I’m having problems getting tenure at Berkeley, but I’d rather talk more generally about the issue of academic repression. The absence of Marxist and other left-wing scholars in the

university is not an accident. We don't have academic freedom and a true marketplace of ideas because the university, like other powerful institutions, serves and reinforces existing political and economic arrangements. The universities are not a forum for controversy, radicalism, or theoretical conflict. On the contrary, they serve to minimize ideological controversy and have become comfortably liberal and static. Most radical scholars can't even enter universities, and those who become radicalized in the course of their university careers risk being fired or not promoted to tenure. What is happening now is that many progressive scholars are coming to realize that their technical and theoretical training is inadequate to explain or change what is happening around the world. As their perspective changes, they become likely casualties of academic repression. This is happening throughout the country right now. Here in Berkeley the Regents and administration are planning to eliminate the School of Criminology for the main reason that it has stopped serving the criminal justice agencies and has become one of their leading critics. Critical scholarship combined with a commitment to practice, Marxist or otherwise, risks repression. We have to learn to stop being surprised when this happens. We should even expect it and almost be pleased because it indicates that we have made clear distinctions between ourselves and the forces of repression. At the same time, this does not mean that we should encourage heroic sacrifices. We need to fight academic repression and develop strategies for supporting and aiding its victims. I'm hopeful that the proposed Union of Radical Criminologists, presently being formed at the University of California's School of Criminology, will address issues like this and ultimately develop into a national organization for promoting radical ideas, community projects and support for the victims of academic repression."